

Westbrook University

Office of Academic Affairs

Policy No: ACAD-ATT-006

Effective: August 1, 2024

Revision: 1.0

Religious Holiday Absence Policy

1. Policy Statement

Westbrook University is committed to supporting the religious and spiritual diversity of its student body. Students will not be penalized academically for absences required for the observance of a sincerely held religious belief or practice.

2. Advance Notice Requirement

Students must provide their instructor with written notice of anticipated religious holiday absences at least 14 calendar days before each anticipated absence. For religious holidays that occur at the very beginning of the semester, students must notify instructors on the first day of class.

Notice should be sent via the student's official Westbrook University email to their instructor and should include the date(s) of absence and the observance being honored.

3. Make-Up Work

Instructors must provide students observing religious holidays with a reasonable opportunity to make up any missed examinations or other required coursework. Make-up work must be of equivalent academic rigor to the original assignment. Instructors may not impose any additional requirements or burdens on students completing make-up work for religious observances.

Students are expected to complete make-up work within 1 week of returning from the absence unless an alternative timeline is negotiated with the instructor.

4. Instructor Responsibilities

Instructors who receive timely notice must acknowledge the request in writing within 3 business days. Instructors may not penalize students for religious absences in any way, including through attendance policies, participation grades, or informal bias. Non-compliance with this policy should be reported to the Office of Equal Opportunity and Diversity.